



Plantar fasciitis exercises

Stretches and calf strength for heel pain. A printable sheet from walkito.site.

How to use this sheet: start with the easier exercises and the lower dose. Mild discomfort is fine; sharp pain is not. If an exercise makes the pain worse the next morning, drop back a step. The doses are Walkito's starting doses, not a prescription. Full guide with videos and the studies: walkito.site/plantar-fasciitis-exercises



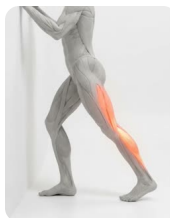
Plantar fascia stretch

2 holds of 30 seconds, each foot

Most sessions

Sit down and cross the foot over the other knee. Pull the toes back until you feel the stretch in the arch, not the calf. Do the first one on the edge of the bed, before your foot touches the floor.

Evidence: Strong. The 2023 heel pain guideline grades stretching A, its top grade.



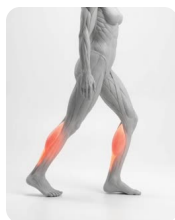
Calf stretch

2 holds of 30 seconds, each leg

Most sessions

Put your hands on a wall. Keep the back leg straight, the heel down and the hips forward. A tight calf pulls on the heel all day, so this stretch matters even though you feel it higher up.

Evidence: Strong. The 2023 heel pain guideline grades stretching A, its top grade.



Soleus stretch

2 holds of 30 seconds, each leg

Most sessions

Take the same position, then bend the back knee until you feel the stretch lower down, near the heel. The soleus, the deeper calf muscle, only lets go with the knee bent.

Evidence: Strong. The 2023 heel pain guideline grades stretching A, its top grade.



Seated heel raises

3 sets of 10, both feet

Strength days

Sit with your feet flat and press up through the balls of your feet. Hands on the knees add resistance. Seated heel raises work the calf with almost no load on the heel.

Evidence: Moderate. The 2023 guideline grades strength work B. This step was not tested on its own.



Heel raises on both feet

3 sets of 10, both feet

Strength days

Stand on both feet, rise straight up over the big toes, then lower slowly. Both feet share the load while the calf wakes up.

Evidence: Moderate. The 2023 guideline grades strength work B. This step was not tested on its own.



Heel raise hold

3 holds of 20 seconds, both feet

Strength days

Rise onto your toes on both feet, then stay still at the top. Don't sink back down. Holding at the top loads the tendon without the bounce.

Evidence: Moderate. The 2023 guideline grades strength work B. This step was not tested on its own.



Heel raises with a towel

4 sets of 10, each leg, with added weight

Strength days

Stand on one foot on a step, with a rolled towel under your toes. Take three seconds to rise, hold for two at the top, and take three seconds to lower. At this level Walkito adds weight, such as a backpack. The towel is what makes this exercise work the plantar fascia and not just the calf.

Evidence: Moderate. This is the routine from a 48-person trial, and the 2023 guideline grades strength work B.



Foot roll

1 minute

Recovery days

Sit and roll the sole of your foot slowly over a massage ball, with firm pressure. If you're wincing, ease off. Rolling settles the tissue after it has worked. No ball? The sole massage uses firm thumb strokes from heel to toes instead.

Evidence: Early. Not tested in the studies on this page. It is here for comfort between sessions.

Week log: tick what you did	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Plantar fascia stretch							
Calf stretch							
Soleus stretch							
Seated heel raises							
Heel raises on both feet							
Heel raise hold							
Morning pain (0 to 10)							

See a clinician first if

- the pain followed an injury or a fall
- you cannot put weight on the foot, or you are limping
- it comes with numbness, tingling, burning, swelling or warmth
- the heel is red, or you have a fever or feel unwell
- it wakes you at night
- it is sharp, or getting worse despite easing the load
- squeezing the sides of the heel hurts, or the pain builds during runs after you increased your mileage; both can be signs of a stress fracture
- you have diabetes, reduced feeling in your feet or poor circulation
- both heels hurt and other joints are swollen or stiff
- it has not improved after several weeks of exercise and a lighter load
- one arch has flattened suddenly as an adult